INTERVIEW GUIDE · STAR DEEP DIVE

# Senior SRE

Platform team · 60 min

CANDIDATE | INTERVIEWER | DATE

**THE CASE**

Our online store makes most of its revenue through checkout. Last month checkout went down for 25 minutes during a campaign, and Black Friday is in six weeks with up to 3 times normal traffic. Leadership wants to know whether we're ready, what it will cost to be ready, and how we'll know in real time if something breaks.

**What this role protects:** Availability customers feel · Revenue protected on peak days · Cloud cost

## HOW TO EVALUATE

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| **S** Situation: a real case, with its business stake | **T** Task: what was theirs to solve, and the goal | **A** Action: what they did and why, options discarded | **R** Result: what changed, in numbers, for the business |

Score: 4 strong (full STAR + business impact) · 3 good · 2 partial · 1 weak

## 1 · UNDERSTAND THE BUSINESS

**1. Tell me about a system you kept running that made money directly. How did you find out what an hour of downtime cost the business?**

Dig deeper: Who gave you that number, and how did it change your priorities?
**Strong answer:** *Knows revenue per minute or a proxy, got it from finance or product, and used it to prioritize.*

Heard ☐ S ☐ T ☐ A ☐ R Score ◯ 1 ◯ 2 ◯ 3 ◯ 4

CANDIDATE'S ANSWER

**2. Before touching anything for Black Friday, what would you ask product and finance about our checkout?**

Dig deeper: Which of those answers would change your plan the most?
**Strong answer:** *Asks peak traffic, revenue per hour, campaigns and acceptable degradation: why before how.*

Heard ☐ S ☐ T ☐ A ☐ R Score ◯ 1 ◯ 2 ◯ 3 ◯ 4

CANDIDATE'S ANSWER

**3. Tell me about an SLO you defined with a business owner. How did you choose the target?**

Dig deeper: What happened the first time you burned the error budget?
**Strong answer:** *Target tied to customer experience and the cost of each extra nine; business owner involved.*

Heard ☐ S ☐ T ☐ A ☐ R Score ◯ 1 ◯ 2 ◯ 3 ◯ 4

CANDIDATE'S ANSWER

**4. In our case, which parts of checkout can degrade on Black Friday and which can never fail? How do you decide?**

Dig deeper: Who signs off on that list?
**Strong answer:** *Separates the payment path from nice-to-haves, decides with product, plans graceful degradation.*

Heard ☐ S ☐ T ☐ A ☐ R Score ◯ 1 ◯ 2 ◯ 3 ◯ 4

CANDIDATE'S ANSWER

## 2 · DESIGN AND TRADE-OFFS

**5. Leadership gives you budget for one thing before Black Friday: more capacity, a load test or better alerts. Which one and why?**

Dig deeper: What do we lose with the options you didn't choose?
**Strong answer:** *Compares cost against revenue at risk per hour; picks with data; names what stays uncovered.*

Heard ☐ S ☐ T ☐ A ☐ R Score ◯ 1 ◯ 2 ◯ 3 ◯ 4

CANDIDATE'S ANSWER



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6 **Tell me about a time you chose between scaling up and fixing the root cause under time pressure. What did each option cost?**

**Dig deeper:** Looking back, was it the right call? What would you change?

**Strong answer:** *Weighs cost, time and risk explicitly, decides consciously and follows up on the debt.*

Heard ☐ S ☐ T ☐ A ☐ R Score ◯ 1 ◯ 2 ◯ 3 ◯ 4

CANDIDATE'S ANSWER

7 **Our database is the bottleneck at 2 times traffic. How would you reach 3 times in six weeks, and how would you explain the cost to leadership?**

**Dig deeper:** What's the cheapest option that still protects revenue?

**Strong answer:** *Options with cost and risk (replicas, cache, queues, limits), picks with data, one-line business case.*

Heard ☐ S ☐ T ☐ A ☐ R Score ◯ 1 ◯ 2 ◯ 3 ◯ 4

CANDIDATE'S ANSWER

8 **Tell me about a cloud cost you reduced without hurting customers. How did you prove it didn't?**

**Dig deeper:** What was the saving per month and what did you watch after the change?

**Strong answer:** *Saving in money, before/after metrics, guardrails and evidence that customers weren't affected.*

Heard ☐ S ☐ T ☐ A ☐ R Score ◯ 1 ◯ 2 ◯ 3 ◯ 4

CANDIDATE'S ANSWER

## 3 · EXECUTION AND INCIDENTS

9 **Tell me about the worst incident you handled. What did it cost the business, and what did you do in the first 15 minutes?**

**Dig deeper:** What did you tell leadership and customers, and when?

**Strong answer:** *Real case, own actions, stops the bleeding first, communicates early, impact quantified.*

Heard ☐ S ☐ T ☐ A ☐ R Score ◯ 1 ◯ 2 ◯ 3 ◯ 4

CANDIDATE'S ANSWER

10 **It's Black Friday, 9 pm, and checkout errors are at 8%. Walk me through your next 30 minutes.**

**Dig deeper:** When do you roll back without knowing the cause?

**Strong answer:** *Mitigates before diagnosing, clear rollback criteria, roles and comms cadence; protects revenue.*

Heard ☐ S ☐ T ☐ A ☐ R Score ◯ 1 ◯ 2 ◯ 3 ◯ 4

CANDIDATE'S ANSWER

11 **Tell me about a postmortem that changed how the company works, not only the code.**

**Dig deeper:** How did you make sure the action items actually happened?

**Strong answer:** *Blameless, business impact stated, a systemic change, owners and dates followed up.*

Heard ☐ S ☐ T ☐ A ☐ R Score ◯ 1 ◯ 2 ◯ 3 ◯ 4

CANDIDATE'S ANSWER

12 **How would you load-test checkout at 3 times traffic without risking real customers or real payments?**

**Dig deeper:** What result would make you tell leadership we're not ready?

**Strong answer:** *Production-like test, payment sandbox, ramp plan and a go/no-go threshold tied to the business.*

Heard ☐ S ☐ T ☐ A ☐ R Score ◯ 1 ◯ 2 ◯ 3 ◯ 4

CANDIDATE'S ANSWER

## 4 · IMPACT AND METRICS

13 **Tell me about reliability work whose value you had to prove. What number did you show, and to whom?**

**Dig deeper:** How did you turn minutes saved into money or customers?

**Strong answer:** *Climbs from output to outcome to impact: incidents and MTTR into downtime avoided and revenue.*

Heard ☐ S ☐ T ☐ A ☐ R Score ◯ 1 ◯ 2 ◯ 3 ◯ 4

CANDIDATE'S ANSWER



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**14** **After Black Friday, which three numbers would you report to show the preparation was worth it?**

**Dig deeper:** Which of them would the CFO care about most?
**Strong answer:** *Availability at peak, failed orders or revenue protected, cost of preparing; compared with last year.*

Heard ☐ S ☐ T ☐ A ☐ R Score ◯ 1 ◯ 2 ◯ 3 ◯ 4

CANDIDATE'S ANSWER

**15** **Tell me about toil you automated. How many hours did it free, and what did the team do with them?**

**Dig deeper:** How did you measure those hours?
**Strong answer:** *Hours measured before and after and reinvested in valuable work, not just 'I automated X'.*

Heard ☐ S ☐ T ☐ A ☐ R Score ◯ 1 ◯ 2 ◯ 3 ◯ 4

CANDIDATE'S ANSWER

**16** **How would you know in real time that Black Friday is going well for the business, not only for the servers?**

**Dig deeper:** Which alert would wake you up?
**Strong answer:** *Business metrics on screen (orders per minute, payment success); alerts on customer impact, not CPU.*

Heard ☐ S ☐ T ☐ A ☐ R Score ◯ 1 ◯ 2 ◯ 3 ◯ 4

CANDIDATE'S ANSWER

## 5 · STAKEHOLDERS AND COMMUNICATION

**17** **Tell me about a time you asked for budget or people for reliability. How did you make the case?**

**Dig deeper:** What did you say the business would lose without it?
**Strong answer:** *Risk of not doing it in money or customers, a clear ask, alternatives and the real outcome.*

Heard ☐ S ☐ T ☐ A ☐ R Score ◯ 1 ◯ 2 ◯ 3 ◯ 4

CANDIDATE'S ANSWER

**18** **Leadership asks 'Are we ready for Black Friday?' and you're not sure. What do you answer?**

**Dig deeper:** How do you say 'not yet' without sounding like a blocker?
**Strong answer:** *Honest status with risks, what's needed and by when, options; no false confidence.*

Heard ☐ S ☐ T ☐ A ☐ R Score ◯ 1 ◯ 2 ◯ 3 ◯ 4

CANDIDATE'S ANSWER

**19** **Tell me about a time you said no to a launch or a change for reliability reasons. How did it end?**

**Dig deeper:** What did you offer instead?
**Strong answer:** *Explains the risk in business terms, offers conditions or an alternative, keeps the relationship.*

Heard ☐ S ☐ T ☐ A ☐ R Score ◯ 1 ◯ 2 ◯ 3 ◯ 4

CANDIDATE'S ANSWER

**20** **How would you explain a 25-minute checkout outage to the sales team in two sentences?**

**Dig deeper:** What would you never say to them?
**Strong answer:** *Plain words: what happened, the impact, what changed. No jargon, no blame, no excuses.*

Heard ☐ S ☐ T ☐ A ☐ R Score ◯ 1 ◯ 2 ◯ 3 ◯ 4

CANDIDATE'S ANSWER

## FINAL ASSESSMENT

STRENGTHS

CONCERNS

AVERAGE SCORE (1-4)

RECOMMENDATION

◯ Strong yes ◯ Yes ◯ No ◯ Strong no

NEXT STEP



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